

Why Your Taco Tuesday Might Cost More: Mexico's Food Prices Are Soaring!

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Have you ever gone to the store and noticed your favorite snacks cost more? In Mexico, families are feeling that pinch big time! At the Mercado de Abastos, a huge food market in Monterrey, prices for everyday foods like tomatoes, potatoes, beef, and chiles have shot up. Cesar Ramirez, a 66-year-old **retiree**, says, "You have to buy them anyway; they're things you use daily." But it's getting harder. Why? Fuel and **fertilizer** prices are rising worldwide because of shipping problems in a place called the **Strait of Hormuz**. That makes it more expensive to grow food and truck it to markets. Plus, some truck drivers and farmers are blocking roads to protest high costs and crime. Elvira Pasillas, a professor, says **low-income** families spend almost 70% of their money on food. That's like if you got \$10 allowance and had to spend \$7 just on lunch! Guillermina Delgado, a 62-year-old housewife, now buys only what she really needs each week. "There's not one single thing that is cheap anymore," she says. Beef prices jumped 16.5% in January alone. Mexico **imports** lots of gasoline from the U.S., so when global oil prices rise, everything costs more. The government is trying to help by cutting **fuel taxes**, but experts worry that might mean less money for other programs that help people. For now, many Mexican families are tightening their belts and hoping prices come down soon.

Word Treasure

Strait of Hormuz -- A narrow water passage in the Middle East where a lot of the world's oil ships travel.

fertilizer -- A substance added to soil to help plants grow, which has become more expensive.

retiree -- A person who has stopped working, usually because they are older.

low-income -- Earning less money than others, making it hard to afford things.

imports -- Buys goods from another country.

fuel taxes -- Money added to the price of gasoline that goes to the government.

Background you need

The Strait of Hormuz is a narrow waterway in the Middle East through which a third of the world's oil tankers pass. When tensions rise there, shipping gets disrupted, making fuel and goods more expensive worldwide.

Mexico buys much of its gasoline from the United States, so when oil prices rise globally, Mexican drivers pay more at the pump.

Monterrey, mentioned in the story, is a large industrial city in northern Mexico where the Mercado de Abastos is one of the biggest food markets.

Break it down

WHO: Mexican families, especially low-income ones and retirees like Cesar Ramirez

WHAT: Food prices are rising sharply because of global problems, making it hard for people to afford everyday meals

WHERE: Mexico, with a focus on the Mercado de Abastos market in Monterrey

WHY: Fuel and fertilizer costs are up due to Strait of Hormuz shipping issues, plus protests and crime raising transport costs, and Mexico relies on imported gasoline

Why it matters

When families in other countries struggle to afford food, it reminds us that the things we buy--like fruits and fuel--can depend on events far away, affecting our own snack prices and family budgets.

Test what you remember

1. What market in Monterrey is mentioned in the story?
 - (A) Mercado de Abastos
 - (B) Mercado de San Juan
 - (C) Mercado Central
 - (D) Mercado de la Merced
2. Why are food prices rising according to the article?
 - (A) Because of a drought in Mexico
 - (B) Because of shipping problems in the Strait of Hormuz
 - (C) Because stores want to make more money
 - (D) Because fewer people are working on farms
3. What percentage of their money do low-income families spend on food?
 - (A) almost 50%
 - (B) almost 70%
 - (C) almost 30%
 - (D) almost 90%
4. How much did beef prices jump in January?
 - (A) 10.5%
 - (B) 16.5%
 - (C) 20.5%
 - (D) 5.5%
5. What does Mexico import a lot from the U.S.?
 - (A) vegetables
 - (B) gasoline
 - (C) avocados
 - (D) corn
6. What is the Mexican government doing to help?
 - (A) giving free food
 - (B) cutting fuel taxes
 - (C) building new roads
 - (D) lowering prices in stores

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: B

1. **Families:** They feel the pinch the most, having to cut back on even basic foods like tomatoes and beef.
2. **Government:** It's trying to help by lowering fuel taxes, but critics worry that may reduce money for other important programs that support people.
3. **Experts like Professor Pasillas:** She points out that rising prices hit poor families hardest, showing how economic problems become personal.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):